

HOST GUIDE / The Last Acquisition

Your role

Run a museum gala, then lead the investigation into donor Grant Larceny’s death. You may play a character: nothing in this guide reveals which evidence letter any character uses or who becomes the murderer. Read the whole guide before printing.

Object of the game

Before the confession, identify the murderer and explain their motive and how the evidence fits. Acting is welcome; reading the supplied answers is enough.

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Party details

October 30, 2026 / 1537 S 74th East Ave, Tulsa, OK 74112. Plan 6:00 arrival to 9:30 finish. Confirm all 15 core roles; add up to 15 optional roles.

01 / Preparation checklist

One week before

- Confirm the guest list and assign character IDs. Include yourself if playing. Use the directory on pages 4–5.
- Send each guest only their introduction PDF or PNG plus the invitation. Do not send the complete kit or a private packet.
- Explain that costume suggestions are inspiration. Guests need no special item to satisfy an evidence clue.
- Decide who reads announcements. A playing host can do it from this guide and the staged F cards.
- Choose the actual rooms for the museum labels using page 8.

Before guests arrive

- Assemble the labeled play, EVIDENCE and FINALE envelopes using page 7.
- Put F1–F5 in a closed host folder, ordered by number. Keep these separate from scavenger discoveries.
- Hide discoveries 1–16; put blank ballots, pencils and question catalogs at seats.
- Prepare the three animal bowls and a closed return box. No guest retains an animal slip.
- Set an Evidence Table and quiet speaking area. Turn music down for seated rounds.
- Leave the spoiler bible and source ZIP unopened if playing.

02 / Materials and copy counts

Item	How many / use
Host guide + attendance roster	One of each for the facilitator
Introduction PDF or PNG	One sent to each assigned guest
Four-page play packet	One labeled packet per guest
A/B preparation receipts	Both cards for each guest, sealed together
Separate FINALE page	One per guest, separately sealed
Question catalog and notes	One complete copy per seating pair; spare copies at the table
Ballots + pencils	One per guest, plus spares
F1-F5 reports	One staged set; read aloud and display
Discoveries 1-16	One hidden set for Act I
Animal cards	Matching 15-animal A/B sets; 15 disjoint optional animals
Containers	Player Bowl A, Murderer Bowl B, Optional Bowl, closed return box
Awards, room signs and exhibits	One set, mounted where useful

Practical supplies

Printer, paper, scissors, envelopes, tape, timer and pens. Print at 100% actual size, single-sided. No font installation is needed. Test an open-freely page on your printer before the full run.

03 / Character directory / 01-15

Assign by personality

IDs 01-15 are the core cast; 16-30 are optional additions. Animals are drawn privately at arrival and are never assigned in this directory.

01	Artie Ficial	Executive Director of the Meridian Museum
02	Claire O'Scuro	Chief Curator of World Cultures
03	Hugh Bidder	International Art Dealer & Collector Liaison
04	Monet Bags	Chief Financial Officer of the Meridian Museum
05	Chip Patina	Chief Conservator
06	Dada DiCapo	Performance Artist & Cultural Celebrity
07	Vincent Van Faux	Celebrated Contemporary Painter
08	Sue Venir	Cultural Property Attorney
09	Dr. Art E. Fact	Professor of Art History & Provenance Scholar
10	Tess Tament	Philanthropist & Heir to the Larceny Family Fortune
11	Barb Dwyer	Director of Museum Security & Former Art-Crimes Investigator
12	Paige Turner	Investigative Arts Journalist
13	Frank Lloyd Wrong	Exhibition Architect & Designer
14	Mona Lott	International Cultural Heritage Envoy
15	Elon Mosaic	Tech Founder, Collector & Museum Patron

03 / Character directory / 16-30

Assign by personality

IDs 01-15 are the core cast; 16-30 are optional additions. Animals are drawn privately at arrival and are never assigned in this directory.

16	Anya Tique	Founding Curator Emerita
17	Saul D. Bid	Chairman of Gavel & Rowe Auction House
18	Elle Loominate	Textile Artist & Designer
19	Reed DeLabel	Doctoral Fellow in Art History
20	Al Baster	Sculptor & Public-Art Star
21	Ella Gance	Collector, Style Patron & Society Fixture
22	Drew Conclusions	Art Critic & Cultural Podcaster
23	Brie DeVivre	Head Caterer & Hospitality Director
24	Cary Crates	Senior Art Handler & Installation Specialist
25	Anne E. Dote	Director of Education & Docent Programs
26	Faye Stop	Gala Photographer & Editorial Portraitist
27	Robin Banks	Cultural Restitution Activist & Nonprofit Organizer
28	Penny Pincher	Eccentric Private Collector
29	Justin Tyme	Tulsa Arts Columnist & Local Historian
30	Minnie Malist	Gala Event Designer & Creative Producer

04 / Memorized animal assignment

At arrival / keep identities private

- Each core guest draws from Player Bowl A. They read silently, memorize the animal, fold the slip and immediately drop it into the closed return box. They never keep it.
- The next guest draws only from Bowl A, not the return box. Once all core arrivals have drawn, unused animals left in A identify absent players.
- Remove those unused words from matching Murderer Bowl B. B now contains exactly the animals memorized by attending core guests.
- Optional guests draw from the separate Optional Bowl, memorize and return their slips in the same way. Optional animals never enter B.
- Do not record animal-to-name associations. Mix returned slips inside the closed box; put it away.

Select after Act I

Ask everyone to keep a neutral face. Draw one animal from B without looking toward guests. Announce the word twice and write only that word on the host cue card. Do not ask who drew it.

Say aloud

If you memorized [ANIMAL], you are the murderer. Use IF MURDERER from now on. Everyone else uses IF INNOCENT. Keep your animal and whether you are innocent or the murderer secret until the finale.

Late arrival

Never redraw the murderer. A late core guest draws from the unused A animals already excluded from B; optional arrivals use their own bowl. They memorize, return the slip and play innocent.

05 / Print, label and seal

Per guest / match by ID and name

- Print the four consecutive play pages from Secret_Individual. Keep them in order and label their PLAY envelope.
- Cut both same-name cards from the evidence sheet. Seal both together in a separate EVIDENCE envelope. A/B letters do not consistently mean innocence or guilt.
- Print that guest's single FINALE page and seal it in a third, separately named envelope. Keep the confession out of the play packet.
- Use 10_Blind_Printing_and_Assembly.pdf to match sheets 01–30 to names without reading the private text.
- Print private documents face down, covering exposed pages. Use a non-playing printing helper if needed.
- At check-in, give PLAY and EVIDENCE to the guest. Keep FINALE envelopes on a host tray until ballots are collected.

Per seating pair

- Supply a complete 11_Questions_and_Notes.pdf, not only its first page. Named questions are in ID order; bookmark the current guests.
- Give each guest a pencil and blank ballot. Keep the host's attendance/hearing roster separate.

Host evidence folder

F1–F2: before Motive. F3: before Opportunity. F4–F5: before Method. Discoveries 1–16 belong in the room; the F reports do not.

06 / Clue placement / Discoveries 1–16

1	Dalmo office / Donor Salon	Inside or beneath a folder
2	Viv office / Registrar	Behind a binder or clipboard
3	Bathroom / Patron Lounge	Near the mirror or folded hand towel
4	Media room / Archives	Inside a magazine or program
5	Laundry / Conservation Lab	Beside cleaning or craft supplies
6	Dalmo office / Donor Salon	Under a legal-size envelope
7	Living room / Grand Gallery	Inside an exhibition catalogue
8	Living room / Grand Gallery	Behind a frame or display card
9	Dining room / Founders Hall	Under an education-program brochure
10	Dalmo office / Donor Salon	Near the room sign or faux security note
11	Media room / Archives	Inside an old-looking notebook
12	Living room / Grand Gallery	Beside an art label or sketch
13	Laundry / Conservation Lab	Under a condition-report clipboard
14	Guest bedroom / Silk Road Gallery	Attached to or inside a prop crate/box
15	Media room / Archives	Near the TV/projector/lighting controls
16	Kitchen / Sculpture Court	Near the buffet/service area

When a clue is found

Ask the finder to bring it to the Evidence Table and read it to nearby guests. Record finds for Curator's Eye. Missing discoveries do not delay the seated investigation.

07 / Timed agenda

6:00–6:20	Arrival; private animal draw, memorize and return
6:20–6:55	Act I: introductions, social tasks and discoveries
6:55–7:05	Buffet; settle in ID order
7:05–7:10	Death announcement and murderer animal selection
7:10–7:30	Act II / Motive: F1–F2, one question and answer each
7:30–8:00	Act II / Opportunity: F3, one question and answer each
8:00–8:30	Act III / Method: F4–F5, answers and selected receipts
8:30–8:45	Compare findings, challenges and deductions
8:45–8:55	Private voting; collect and lock every ballot
8:55–9:15	Tally, accusations and separate sealed confession
9:15–9:30	Awards, dessert and debrief

Timing guidance

Budget 80 minutes for the three seated rounds with 30 guests. Keep each question/answer turn to about 40 seconds; Method needs about a minute with its receipt. With 15 guests, allow more discussion or finish earlier. Pause eating during spoken turns. These estimates still need a human rehearsal.

08 / Act I / Welcome and gossip

Say aloud at arrival

Welcome to the Meridian Museum's Treasures of the World gala. Grant Larceny expects gratitude, good manners and his name on absolutely everything. Open only the first page of your play packet. Introduce yourself, pursue your three tasks and explore the museum. Leave the later pages and your evidence envelope alone for now.

Lead the opening

- Invite each guest to say their character name and role. A sentence from the introduction is enough. Allow 15–20 seconds each.
- Then let guests mingle in small groups. Their private tasks give them people and topics to seek out.
- Encourage gossip about the donor's decisions and found documents. Nobody has to invent an event or a private relationship.
- Move quiet guests into a small conversation; they can read a task or introduction instead of performing.
- At 6:55 call for buffet and ID-order seats. Mark attendance. Make sure every pair can reach a question catalog.

Say aloud at the death

Grant Larceny has been found dead in the Donor Salon. His private cordial was poisoned. Please keep a neutral face while I draw the murderer's animal.

Then

Follow page 6's animal announcement. Do not ask the selected guest to identify themselves. Move directly to Motive.

09 / Act II / Round 1: Motive

Release

Read F1 / The private toast, then F2 / Grant's unfinished business, verbatim from the staged report cards. Put both on the Evidence Table.

Say aloud

Grant's papers show that his generosity came with conditions. Some of you were about to lose money, work, reputation or an object you cared about. Turn to Round 1 / Motive. Ask the named Motive questions in the catalog. We need to hear from everyone.

Run the question chain

- Start with the lowest attending ID. The last seated guest asks that person's named question from the catalog.
- The respondent reads the answer for their role from the current page, then asks the next occupied seat their named question. Continue in order, skipping absent IDs.
- Tick each answered ID on the roster. Everyone answers once. Labels stay private; only the speech box is read.
- For a guest who prefers help, a neighbour may read the speech box they indicate. Do not ask which role they are using.

Close the round

Ask pairs: Who stood to lose something? Which grievance sounds most urgent? Give two minutes to compare notes, then announce Opportunity. A motive alone is not a solution.

10 / Act II / Round 2: Opportunity

Release

Read F3 / The salon door register verbatim. Display it beside F1–F2. Do not release F4 or F5 yet.

Say aloud

We know when the drink was prepared and when Grant drank it. The door register tells us who could reach the service table between those events. Turn to Round 2 / Opportunity. Ask the named Opportunity questions, including the ordinary setup errands involving the cabinet key.

Run the question chain

- Start with the lowest attending ID. The last seated guest asks that person's named question from the catalog.
- The respondent reads the answer for their role from the current page, then asks the next occupied seat their named question. Continue in order, skipping absent IDs.
- Tick each answered ID on the roster. Everyone answers once. Labels stay private; only the speech box is read.
- For a guest who prefers help, a neighbour may read the speech box they indicate. Do not ask which role they are using.

Close the round

Give pairs two minutes: Who visited after the drink was poured? What setup errands might matter? Keep several suspects under consideration. Then announce Method and ask everyone to wait while the next reports are read.

11 / Act III / Round 3: Method

Release

Read F4 / The missing conservation sample and F5 / A thread in the poison verbatim. Display both before anyone opens their EVIDENCE envelope.

Say aloud

The cabinet key gave access to the missing sample. The poisoned linen smear tells us how it was applied. Several guests had ordinary reasons to borrow the key or carry that linen. Turn to Round 3 / Method. Open EVIDENCE and privately select the letter your page assigns. Leave the other card hidden.

Collect and run

- Collect one selected card per attending ID. Count against the roster and return it to its owner. The guest chooses the letter privately.
- Use the same seat-order question chain. Ask each named Method question. The guest reads their selected speech, then the whole selected receipt.
- Put each read receipt on the Evidence Table and tick that ID. Do not move on with a missing receipt.
- Compare the door, key and linen findings in pairs. Name a suspect, motive and link between the reports.
- Allow up to three challenges. A challenged guest can repeat their printed facts; no new factual alibi or object can be introduced.

If discussion stalls

Ask: Which findings overlap? Does your suspect fit all the reports, or only one?

12 / Votes, confession and awards

Lock the decision

- Give everyone a private ballot. Ask for suspect, motive and supporting evidence. The murderer votes too and may accuse another guest.
- Collect every ballot before distributing FINALE envelopes. Once collected, no votes change.
- Tally suspect votes. For Escaped Justice, include every positive-vote suspect tied at the third-place cutoff; zero-vote names never qualify.
- Invite a few brief accusations while keeping the murderer's identity secret. Do not read final statements yet.

Say aloud

The ballots are locked. Whoever memorized [ANIMAL], please identify yourself. Open only your own FINALE envelope and read the confession. Everyone else leaves theirs sealed.

After the confession

- Master Sleuth: a ballot naming the murderer with their motive and a coherent link between the salon, key and linen evidence. Share the prize if reasoning is equally strong.
- Escaped Justice: the murderer wins if outside the qualifying top-three suspects.
- Best Actor and Best Costume: use ballot votes. Curator's Eye: use the Act I discovery tally.
- Offer dessert and debrief. Guests may now discuss their alternative branches.

13 / Quick cues and troubleshooting

Start	Welcome / introductions / tasks and discoveries
Select	Memorized animals / remove unused A from B / draw / announce
Motive	F1-F2 / page 2 / named questions / tick all IDs
Opportunity	F3 / page 3 / named questions / tick all IDs
Method	F4-F5 / page 4 / assigned card / count all / questions/receipts
Decide	Compare / challenges / private votes / lock all ballots
Reveal	Ask announced animal to identify / distribute FINALE / confession
Finish	Awards / dessert / debrief

If something goes wrong

- Forgotten animal before selection: quietly say so. Void the assignment round and restart for everyone, with no identity list. Never guess or borrow another guest's word.
- Forgotten animal after selection: stop. Never guess identity. Restart with fresh memorized assignments only if all core guests can do so; otherwise postpone scoring.
- Wrong evidence card: the guest privately rechecks the IF INNOCENT / IF MURDERER line and swaps to their assigned letter before voting. Do not inspect their other branch.
- Missing guest: skip their ID. Remove their unused animal before selection. A missing optional role cannot block an essential clue.
- Someone reads ahead: stop them before any confession is spoken. FINALE remains on the host tray until ballots are locked.
- Room drifting? Lower music, pause eating and resume the roster.